

They get your action, not your profile

A matching rule for a job market where AI makes applying free

Daniel Bulla, Bratislava · September 2026 · Two-page summary of the General Matchmaking Protocol (v4.0). A design proposal: nothing here is deployed or tested yet.

The problem

AI tools now write a tailored application in seconds. So applications multiply, employers screen harder, often with automated ranking, and each application tells them less. On Slovakia's largest job portal, job ads fell 16% in 2025 while the average ad drew 29 responses, a record [1]. The usual fix is to score applicants more precisely. That builds an ever more detailed file on each person, held by the side with more power, and it does not bring back the signal that was lost.

The rule

The person keeps the full picture. Organisations receive only what the person deliberately chooses to send.

- **Fit is checked on the person's side.** The person, or an assistant working only for them, compares their own profile with a published role and sees whether and why it fits. That assessment never leaves their side.
- **The organisation gets the act, not the analysis.** It receives the application and a short piece of work the person chose. Never a fit score, rank, personality type or inferred trait.
- **A few serious applications per month.** Each person has a small monthly allowance of high-stakes applications (five for now; the right number is open). Because they are scarce, they carry meaning.
- **A reply promise.** Each role names who reads applications and by when they reply. A role with no active reader cannot receive applications, which removes ghost vacancies by design.

Why this might work

Markets that faced the same flood have already used scarce signals. In the job market for new economists, applicants can send a limited number of signals of interest. Applications with a signal led to an interview 31.5% of the time, against 24.7% without one; the authors present this as an association, not proof of cause [2]. In a dating-site experiment, attaching one of a few scarce "roses" to a proposal substantially raised acceptance [3]. Hiring platforms are already moving this way: since June 2025 Greenhouse has let job seekers flag one "dream job" a month, and it reports that those applicants are hired at roughly five times the usual rate [6]. The disclosure side builds on familiar principles: data minimisation (GDPR Article 5(1)(c)) and contextual integrity, the idea that information should flow only in ways that fit the context it came from [4]. Law already draws such lines: Slovakia's 2026 equal pay act gives applicants the right to know the starting pay range before an interview and bars employers from asking what they earn now or earned before [5].

What it is not

Not a new job platform, and not an AI that decides who fits. Nobody computes a score about a person for anyone else. It is a rule that existing job boards, public employment services or data-sharing systems (for example personal data stores) could adopt.

Where it could break

Where it could break	What the design does, and what is still open
The right number of applications per month	Five is a placeholder. Too few shuts people out; too many and the signal means nothing again. This is the main research question.
People with few options	Scarce applications sit on top of ordinary ones, not instead of them. Whether that is enough protection needs testing.
Gaming with extra accounts	Treated as a norm and measured at first. Later: one allowance per verified person.
Why would employers adopt it?	Fewer, more serious applications and fewer ghost vacancies. Unproven; a pilot has to show it.
Enforcing "no score"	The first message has fixed fields per role, so there is nowhere to put a score. Copying after reading cannot be stopped technically.

How to test it cheaply

- **Simulation.** Calibrate a model from published application and response data, then vary the monthly allowance and measure interview rates, time to first human reply, and the share of people who get no contact at all.
- **Small pilot.** Start where stakes are lower, such as volunteering, where the same pattern appears: long first-step forms and many unanswered applications. Measure the share of applications answered by the promised date.

Beyond hiring

Work has long been where adults meet people outside their family: colleagues, mentors, friends. If AI thins out work, that side effect thins too. The same rule applies to meeting people: two people see whether they fit only if both say yes, and no third party ranks them or decides who should meet.

What I am looking for

Critique of the mechanism, data that could calibrate the monthly allowance, and people who study or run matching markets and would like to test it. The full specification is available on request.

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Sources

- [1] Profesia.sk annual statistics for 2025, as reported by oPeniazoch.sk (2026).
- [2] Coles, Cawley, Levine, Niederle, Roth and Siegfried (2010), "The Job Market for New Economists: A Market Design Perspective", Journal of Economic Perspectives 24(4), Table 3.
- [3] Lee and Niederle (2015), "Propose with a rose? Signaling in internet dating markets", Experimental Economics 18(4).
- [4] Regulation (EU) 2016/679 (GDPR), Art. 5(1)(c); Nissenbaum (2004), "Privacy as Contextual Integrity", Washington Law Review 79(1).
- [5] Slovak Act No. 76/2026 Coll. on equal pay for men and women, Section 4(2) to 4(4), in force since 7 June 2026.
- [6] Greenhouse, "Greenhouse Launches Dream Job" (5 June 2025); Fortune, 27 July 2026, reporting Greenhouse's figures (a correlation, not a controlled result).